Reforming Where We Vote

Upon invitation from the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters conducting an investigation into all aspects of the 2025 Federal Election, I request that the following proposals be taken into consideration.

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[redacted]

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APPENDIX **6**

User Friendly, Fairer, and Economical Voting Centres

Proposal: Only one voting centre per electorate.

Unnecessary Plethora of Voting Centres (VCs)

Together with Early Voting Centres for two weeks prior to each election, the AEC also resources, with staff and equipage, on average 52 election day voting centres/booths for every lower house electorate. For the greater majority of metropolitan voters it would be fair to say that there is a voting booth, if not two, within walking distance of their residence. As this is more ubiquitous than Aldi, Coles or Woolworths supermarkets, where local residents would visit as often as twice per week, it does seem an unnecessary waste of resources to supply so many voting booths for only triennial visits.

Some Problems with Multiple Voting Centres

Higher Costs

Economies of Scale

Due to the economic concept of 'economies of scale', for the AEC:

- to deliver, and recoup after election, resources for the voting of approximately 120,000 registered voters is more expensive when at 52 centres than one,
- more staff per voter are needed at 52 centres than one,
- more equipment such as booths, tables and signs, per voter, are needed at 52 centres than one.

For the same reasons, candidates and parties also suffer increased expenses.

Inability of AEC to adequately proportion ballot papers

As highlighted during the Victorian Electoral Commissioner's personal appearance to the Electoral Matters Committee on 27th March 2023 there was a much complained of problem at the previous election of VCs running out of ballot papers. This facet of the election is surprising considering the excess number of papers printed.

"As a ball park figure, we generally print approximately **nine million** ballots for 4.4 million electors." – Mr Ben Sutherland of the AEC at the above inquiry[i].

The reason for this excess is that it is very difficult for planers to estimate how may voters will attend each of the Victorian 20 VCs.

There is then obviously no reason why estimating the correct number of voters who attend 52 centres would be any easier.

Less than Perfect Ballot Paper Security

- Voter fraud is **not** rampant under the auspices of the AEC, but that is still no reason to refrain from doing everything reasonably possible to minimise the opportunities for corruption. Bearing in mind that voters are given pencils to mark their ballot papers, and there are always recalcitrant attendees at polling stations who surrender their ballot papers unmarked, it would not be that difficult, for those inclined, to complete papers, using erasers where necessary, according to their own preferences if they had private access to such ballots for a time.
- This possibility is not as farfetched as one might think, considering that in 2013 at the Australian federal election, the Australian Electoral Commission "lost" 1,375 completed W.A. Senate ballot papers[ii], leading to a repeat Senate election for the state the following year.
- Currently there are on average 52 discrete instances of surrendered ballot papers being transported to the central electorate office from outlier booths, a number well in excess of the number needed if there was a single VC.

Institutional disadvantage against small parties

"…majority or plurality [electoral] systems effectively reward strong parties and penalize weak ones…"[iii]

On Election Day 2025, there were 7,850[1] VCs scattered throughout Australia. This divides up into an average of 52 centres for every House of Representatives electorate. Whereas, prima facie, it would appear a good thing that there should be many centres so as to minimise the travel difficulties for voters, an unfortunate by-product of this arrangement is that it makes it extremely difficult, if not impossible, for small political parties, with commensurate fewer supporters, to hand out HTV cards, let alone scrutineer, at every centre.

Whereas some might respond to this by saying that as a small party is, by nature, a less popular party and one that cannot win government, then it is par for the course, and not an injustice, that it may experience such difficulties.
However, this may well be an incorrect interpretation of the situation.

The right to exist, represent, and speak up

Whereas a larger party will enter an election with the sole goal of winning government, it is still a necessary function of democracy to have other candidates, subject to their popularity, winning seats in either house of parliament on what is called 'the crossbench'. These successful candidates fulfill the legitimate and worthy function of speaking up for minority political interests in the Australia's legislative body, Parliament, a word which derives from the French 'parler', meaning 'to speak'.

"Democracy [also] means minority voices are heard…"[2]

Thus, it is quite unreasonable and unfair to deny the voter the opportunity to, if they so wish, make contact at the polling station with all independent candidates or political party's representatives, so as to become more informed of their policies and/or candidate. This is especially so when considering, in arranging such, there would be **no added financial burden** to the taxpayer.

Specifics of a Better Voting Centre (VC) System

- Reduce the number of VCs from over 7,850 to 150[3], being one centre per lower house electorate. The centre would need to be large enough to triple the average current VC rate of processing election day voters; from a voter every 42.8 seconds to one every 14.3 seconds.

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[1] Best estimate of a total of 8,200 voting centres less approximately 350 early voting.

[2] O'Neil, Clare. Minister for Home Affairs. 'Freedoms and Rights for all', *Strengthening Australian democracy – A practical agenda for democratic resilience*, 2024.

[3] In rural electorates voters not resident at the locality of the VC would have to consider if they had the opportunity to travel there during the two-week voting period. If the general rural consensus was not supportive of the change, then more VCs would be supplied in said electorates, even if up to the existing number.

- Abolish what are known as 'Early Voting Centres' and have each electorate VC open for 12 days, beginning on a Monday.
  - Opening hours to be 6.30 am – 10 pm weekdays, and 8 am – 6 pm Saturdays.
- Arrangements:
  - Ancillary facilities
    - Local charities to run sausage sizzles and other refreshments stalls on the VC grounds.

    - Political parties and independent candidates permitted to operate a maximum of one stall each on the VC grounds not too distant from voter pathway. All stalls to have two metre (suggested) perimeter markings which cannot be crossed by campaigners. Campaigning still permitted off VC property.
  - Addressing long queues
    - An AEC website published for every electorate displaying current voter queue waiting time.
    - An AEC app to be able to be downloaded which allows the user to receive a text whenever the queue for his/her electorate goes below an optional number he/she has chosen.
    - Possibility of a 'take your number' machine at booth entry whereby voters take a number then sit down on AEC supplied seating, or otherwise take advantage of refreshment stalls or visit party stalls. 'Next' number either called out or displayed on large screen.

  - Transport
    - Similar to the concept of RSL shuttle buses traversing the local area to pick up and drop off clients, buses with highly visible AEC markings could be utilised throughout the electorate during the fortnight offering to transport, without charge, aged voters as well as those with mobility difficulties.
  - Voter Information Pack
    - Packs to be posted out to all enrolled electorate residents informing them of:
      - Address of VC,
      - Opening days and times,
      - Website address to enquire of current waiting times,
      - Where to download the AEC app,
      - Schedule and routes of AEC shuttle buses.

Benefits

Comfort

Currently the voting experience can be where we either are waiting in line 25 minutes being harassed by party activists pushing HTV cards into a face, or finding a small quite VC with no activists but wishing to know something about the final four candidates one has to compulsorily mark off.
Like the Agora of ancient Greece, a voting centre could be a hub of social activity. People, who wish to, could inquire of parties their policies, be refreshed with food and drink, sit down and contemplate their decision, and eventually exercise their democratic right while waiting only an acceptable time as informed by their AEC phone app.

Lower Costs

- As mentioned above, due to economies of scale, using larger centres to accommodate more people would minimise duplication of services and thus be a cost saver.
- Ballot papers printed would only be slightly more than the number of enrolled voters, together with estimated absentee voters, compared to current system where almost **double** the necessary amount is printed to mostly account for incorrect estimation of attendances at each booth.
- Fewer cardboard booths as well as vote receptacle boxes manufactured as each used to accommodate more voters over the fortnight.

Higher Calibre of Voting Centre Managers

As there are "1,800 voting centres on election Saturday [for Victoria State Election], every one of those with a voting centre manager, … – there will be inconsistencies. Look, I accept that entirely. We do everything we can, and potentially there are voting centre managers and others that we have recruited that perhaps are not up to the task,…" – VEC Commissioner Warwick Gately at above mentioned hearing.

With only 150 managers to appoint at federal elections, not only could the selection process be a lot more discriminating, but more resources could be invested in educating and training those 150 appointees rather than over seven thousand.

Voter Friendly

- With only one VC per electorate minor political party representatives (who otherwise would be spread too thin on the ground) could have access to all voters to explain their party's position on issues as well as handing out 'how to vote' cards, thus decreasing the chances of voters 'voting blind' with no more information than what is on the AEC ballot paper.

- Online AEC notice board giving current wait times at the VC.

Problem of the Absence of a Local VC

The alleged justification for this overabundance of centres is that for something as important as an election, no person should be disadvantaged in any way from attending a booth to exercise their democratic right.

That Cumbersome Quadrennial Burden

However as against this, there are factors to be taken into account. Whereas the average electorate accommodates 52 voting centres, it accommodates **far fewer** supermarkets. People can travel there to buy their needed groceries, but they can't travel a shorter distance to undertake their democratic responsibility?
If exercising your democratic right is so important (which for most it is), is it really that demanding to get in your car, or on the bus, tram, train, shuttle bus, or even catch a taxi, to manifest your political desire at the VC, for at most an hour, *once every three years*?

Shuttle Buses

Voters who might have difficulties in travelling far to a voting booth could very possibly be accommodated by the AEC arranging brightly decked out shuttle buses temporarily marked with electorate name and AEC colours, following set routes and times, perpetually driving around the electorate picking up and dropping off back home elderly or otherwise disabled voters.

Appendix

Smiling men photo: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Box_13_scandal

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[i] https://new.parliament.vic.gov.au/2022electioninquiry
[ii] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2014_Australian_Senate_special_election_in_Western_Australia
[iii] "Proportional Representation" Encyclopaedia Britannica (on-line)